

Professor/Mentor Rules

advice i got from professors, mentors, and reviewers. some of this was direct feedback, some was from reading between the lines of rejection letters and edit rounds. all of it matters.

on references

“Reference list: it seems to be random. Cite closely related papers, and only those. For example, you are citing Akerlof, which is an important (but very old) paper on the market for lemons. Most papers cited (except one or two papers on going private) seem to be unrelated to your current paper. They usually suggest low quality.”

what this means: every reference in your bibliography should make the reviewer nod and think “yes, that belongs there.” if they see a famous paper that has nothing to do with your topic, they assume you’re padding. they’re usually right.

the fix: go through your reference list one by one. for each paper, ask: if i removed this citation, would my argument break? if the answer is no, remove it. if yes, make sure you actually discuss it in the text, not just cite it.

on ai detection

reviewers and editors are getting better at spotting llm-written papers. the tells are: perfectly uniform paragraphs, overuse of “furthermore” and “moreover,” abstracts that read like they were generated from a template, and a complete absence of personal voice.

what this means: you can use ai tools for formatting and checking. you cannot use them to write your paper. the line is: did you think of this idea yourself? did you write this sentence yourself? if both are yes, you’re fine. if either is no, rewrite it.

the fix: read your paper out loud. if you wouldn’t say it that way to a friend, don’t write it that way. add personal perspective. say “i found” instead of “it was found.” say “this surprised me” if something surprised you. be a person.

on figures

a figure that looks sloppy kills your credibility faster than a typo. reviewers look at figures first. if the figures are clean, they assume the work is clean. if the figures are messy, they assume the work is messy.

what this means: spend disproportionate time on figures. no overlapping text. no arrows that cross boxes. no labels that run off the page. consistent fonts. consistent colors. white space is your friend.

the fix: generate figures at high dpi (300+). use `tight_layout()` or `constrained_layout`. view every figure at 100% zoom before submitting. if anything looks off, fix it.

on desk rejection

most papers get rejected before they reach reviewers. the editor reads the abstract, skims the introduction, checks the reference list, and decides in 5-10 minutes. you need to survive those 10 minutes.

common desk rejection reasons: - paper doesn't fit the journal's scope (read the aims and scope page) - obviously ai-written (see above) - reference list is padded or missing key papers - no clear contribution stated in the abstract - formatting doesn't match journal requirements - author affiliation is missing or suspicious

the fix: before submitting, pretend you're the editor. read only the abstract, introduction, and conclusion. flip through the figures. scan the references. would you send this to reviewers? if not, fix what's broken.

on the first submission

your first submission to a real journal is terrifying. that's normal. everyone's first submission was terrifying. the difference between people who publish and people who don't is that the ones who publish hit submit anyway.

what this means: the paper will never feel perfect. you will always find something to fix. at some point, you have to stop editing and send it. the reviewers will find things to improve — that's their job. your job is to give them something worth improving.

the fix: set a deadline. when the deadline arrives, submit whatever you have. don't let perfect be the enemy of submitted.

on handling rejection

you will get rejected. probably multiple times. every published author you admire has a folder full of rejection letters. it's part of the process, not a judgment on your work.

what to do when rejected: 1. wait 24 hours before reading the reviews (seriously) 2. read the reviews. separate factual errors from stylistic opinions 3. fix the factual errors 4. consider the stylistic opinions but don't accept all of them 5. submit somewhere else 6. the paper gets better every round

on writing like a human

the best academic writing sounds like a smart person explaining something they care about. not like a committee wrote it. not like a template generated it. like a person.

rules for human-sounding academic writing: - use contractions sometimes (don't, can't, it's) - start sentences with "and" or "but" occasionally - ask rhetorical questions sparingly - use "i" when stating your own contributions - vary paragraph length (some 2-sentence paragraphs, some 8-sentence) - read hemingway. then read your paper. find the middle ground.